

ANI

THE 'MGR LOOK' AIADMK partymen give new party general secretary EPS a makeover

interim relief. The judges said they would hear their appeals on April 20 and 21.

The 68-year-old EPS, then, stands on very solid ground. A jaggery trader-turned-politician from western Tamil Nadu, his political career has seen a remarkable rise, from suddenly becoming chief minister to taking control of the party. As for EPS's leadership style, political analyst Ramu Manivannan says, "He can be strong-willed, wily and ruthless. But his biggest advantage is that he has no image to lose. There are no legends here. Neither MGR nor JJ was free from these fears."

THE COURTS HAVE SIDED WITH EPS, WHO NOW HAS THE POST OF GENERAL SECRETARY OF THE AIADMK

The first priority of EPS will be to restore the confidence of the cadre, which, sources say, will begin by acknowledging the supporters who stood with him as he battled to abolish dual control and take the reins of the party himself. He will also have to resolve the crisis over the party's 'Two Leaves' symbol, something that the AIADMK cadre holds dear. "It will bother EPS till the Election Commission formally allots it to him," says analyst N. Sathiya Moorthy.

As for OPS, he has few options left. Joining hands with Sasikala and her nephew T.T.V. Dhinakaran and his Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam is a possibility. They are all from the Mukkalathore (Thevar) community that has pockets of influence in southern Tamil Nadu.

Political analysts also believe that the current churn within the AIADMK is more of a setback for the BJP than the OPS-Sasikala-Dhinakaran combine, especially since the state unit led by K. Annamalai is trying to position itself as a major opposition party. The saffron party's best bet would be to continue playing second fiddle to the AIADMK if it wants to win Lok Sabha seats from Tamil Nadu in 2024.

But there is deep distrust between the AIADMK and BJP despite the seeming bonhomie. Both EPS and Annamalai are from the Gounder community, but it's still not enough to get them on the same page. Analysts say EPS may have second thoughts on a poll tie-up as there is pressure from a section of the cadre who say that identifying with the Hindutva party was the main cause for the AIADMK's rout in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. Ironically, the only seat it won then was bagged by OPS's son P. Ravindranath. ■

(Kurmis being the 'Luv') that is the bedrock of Nitish's social support base.

Since 2005, if Nitish's Janata Dal (United) repeatedly succeeded against the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD)'s strong vote bank of Muslims and Yadavs (or M-Y, who together account for about 27 per cent of the state's electorate), it was largely because of this Luv-Kush unity besides the support of the Extremely Backward Classes (EBC). Those entrenched in Bihar's politics estimate the Kushwahas constitute no less than six per cent of the state's population.



ANI

The BJP is acutely aware that Bihar, which sends 40 parliamentarians to the Lok Sabha and is set for a bipolar contest between its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and Nitish's Mahagathbandhan, can be a zero-sum game. No wonder, that up against the formidable voter base of the JD(U)-RJD ruling alliance, the odds of skimming a chunk of the Kushwaha vote from Nitish look so tempting that the BJP has junked its well-established convention of picking only the dyed-in-the-wool saffron men as party presidents in Bihar. The son of veteran politician Shakuni Choudhary, Samrat started his political career with the RJD in 1999. In 2014, he switched loyalties to the JD(U) before joining the BJP in 2017.

It's apparent the BJP's strategy hinges on denting Nitish's vote bank if it wants the NDA to repeat—or at least not slip much behind—its 2019 tally of 39 seats (of which the then ally JD(U) accounted for 16). The saffron party has already warmed up to Upendra Kushwaha, who broke away from the JD(U) last month to float his own outfit and has been dropping hints of joining hands with the BJP in the Lok Sabha polls. The Centre's decision to provide him Y-Plus security, though attributed to intelligence inputs, is being seen as its proof. But Samrat's elevation also proves that the BJP is not willing to put all its eggs in Upendra's basket.

The move also suggests another paradigm shift in the state BJP. Apart from Samrat, the party has at the helm Bhumihar leader and former assembly speaker Vijay Kumar Sinha, who is now the Leader of Opposition. Their bitter argument in the Bihar assembly in 2021 still etched in public memory, the two will have to put up a united face to corner their communities' votes, which together account for 11 per cent of the electorate. With the BJP desperately looking to break ground with new social groups, Samrat seems to have his hands full. ■